

11 Structuring and talking about arguments

A Structuring arguments

On the one hand¹, I don't think that schoolchildren should have mobile phones at school. It's too easy for them to get distracted on social media. **On the other hand**², they are a useful way for kids to get in touch with their parents when there is a crisis. **Be that as it may**³, it is still a nuisance when phones go off in the middle of a lesson. To put it **in a nutshell**⁴, there are a lot of **pros and cons**⁵ with regard to kids and mobiles.



- ¹ and ² these phrases are used to present two opposite facts or two different ways of looking at the same issue
³ an expression which means you accept that something is true, but it still does not change your opinion
⁴ indicates that you're describing something as briefly as you can
⁵ advantages and disadvantages

B Noun phrases relating to arguments

She's caught in **a vicious circle**. She gets depressed, so she buys some new clothes, so she has no money, which makes her depressed again. [a problem that cannot be solved because it causes another problem that causes the first problem again]

Don't let's get onto corruption in the police. That would really be opening **a can of worms**! [a problem which you do not want to deal with because it will cause trouble (informal)]

The producer says critics love the film, but box-office takings will provide **the acid test**. [a key test which will prove the value, quality or truth of something]

Certainly, boarding school is hard for children. **The other side of the coin** is that they learn to be independent. [a different view, making something look either better or worse than before]

C Talking about arguments

idiom	meaning	example
tie yourself (up) in knots	become very confused when you are trying to explain something	Fiona tried to explain the problem, but she soon tied herself up in knots.
be brought/called to account	be forced to explain your actions and (probably) punished	The Ministers responsible should be called to account for their incompetence.
give someone the benefit of the doubt	believe something good about someone even though you could believe either good or bad	I'm not sure that David is telling the truth, but I'm giving him the benefit of the doubt.
go round in circles	make no progress in an argument or discussion	We're going round in circles. I wish you'd come up with a new idea!
won't budge/give an inch	won't modify an opinion or agree to even small changes that another person wants	I'm prepared to compromise, but Bert won't budge an inch.

Exercises

11.1 Match the beginning of each idiom on the left with its ending on the right.

- | | | |
|-------------------------|--------------------------|------------|
| 1 a can of | ☐ | a circle |
| 2 the acid | ☐ | b hand |
| 3 a vicious | ☐ | c nutshell |
| 4 in a | ☐ | d coin |
| 5 on the other | ☐ | e inch |
| 6 the other side of the | ☐ | f circles |
| 7 tie yourself up in | ☐ | g worms |
| 8 go round in | ☐ | h knots |
| 9 be called to | ☐ | i test |
| 10 won't give an | ☐ | j account |

11.2 What are the situations describing? Match an idiom from the box with each situation.

a vicious circle going round in circles putting it in a nutshell the acid test
tying yourself up in knots the pros and cons of a situation

- Trying out a new invention for the first time.
- Trying to explain something complex that you do not really understand.
- The advantages and disadvantages of moving to a different town.
- Explaining a complicated situation in two minutes.
- Trying to reach agreement when neither side is prepared to modify its position.
- Getting rid of some books so you have space on your bookshelves, then buying more books because you now have space, so you now need to get rid of more books to clear a bit more space.

11.3 Complete each sentence with an idiom from the box.

a can of worms called to account on the one hand be that as it may
give him the benefit of the doubt the other side of the coin

- In some ways it's glamorous being a pop star. But is that you no longer have any privacy.
- It's time these petty criminals were for their irresponsible actions.
- I know Bill's a nice friendly person, but,, he still has to pull his weight in the office.
-, I think Janna might have the best personality for the job, but, on the other, Mina has more experience.
- If he's apologised, I think you should
- It would be opening to inquire about his finances.

11.4 Rewrite the underlined part of each sentence with an idiom.

- I got very confused trying to explain to Karl how I felt about him.
- I'd like you to write an essay on the advantages and disadvantages of working abroad.
- To put it briefly, James needs to produce better homework.
- Natasha was prepared to compromise, but Alex wouldn't compromise at all.
- You need more money so you work more. You earn more so you spend more. So you need to work more. It never ends.